CYBER SAFETY GUY

The Platforms Your Child Is Using:

A Parent's Plain-English Guide

Most children are not using just one app – they are moving between multiple platforms every day. Messaging, video, gaming, and AI tools all overlap. This guide breaks down the most common platforms and what parents need to know.

Most teens use **5+** platforms regularly

Messaging + video apps dominate daily use

Risks often come from how apps connect together

WHAT'S INSIDE

01 The top platforms
02 What they're used for
03 Why they're popular
04 Where risks sit
05 Patterns across apps
06 How to approach it

01 THE TOP 10 PLATFORMS

1 TikTok
- Used for: Endless short videos, trends and entertainment
- Watch for: Algorithm exposure, risky trends, live content

2 YouTube
- Used for: Videos, Shorts, creators, learning
- Watch for: Autoplay, inappropriate content, long sessions

3 Snapchat
- Used for: Daily messaging, snaps and streaks
- Watch for: Snap Map, disappearing messages, reply pressure

4 Instagram
- Used for: Posts, Reels, stories, DMs
- Watch for: Private messaging, comparison, body image

5 WhatsApp
- Used for: Group chats, family, school and friends
- Watch for: Large groups, bullying, unknown contacts

6 Roblox
- Used for: Games, creating, chatting with others
- Watch for: User-generated content, in-app purchases, strangers

7 Discord
- Used for: Private servers, gaming, communities
- Watch for: Hidden conversations, inappropriate content, weak moderation

8 BeReal
- Used for: Daily real-life posts with friends
- Watch for: Location clues, social pressure, oversharing

9 Fortnite
- Used for: Gaming, building, voice chat
- Watch for: Open voice chat, strangers, in-game purchases

10 ChatGPT & other AI tools
- Used for: Homework help, answers, advice, creativity
- Watch for: Misinformation, over-reliance, privacy

WHAT PARENTS NEED TO UNDERSTAND

1. **It's not one app – it's an ecosystem**
   Children move between platforms constantly.
2. **Messaging sits underneath everything**
   Most risks happen in private conversations.
3. **Features matter more than the app**
   Chat, live, and sharing tools carry the risk.



BY THE NUMBERS

5+ platforms used regularly

Multiple group chats per child

Daily switching between apps

SAFETY FEATURES / SETTINGS

WHAT EXISTS	WHAT TO CHANGE
Privacy settings on most platforms	Set accounts to private
Blocking and reporting tools	Limit who can contact your child
Screen time controls	Turn off location sharing where possible

STEP-BY-STEP SAFETY GUIDE

1. **Know the apps they use**
   Ask them to show you.
2. **Focus on behaviour, not banning**
   How they use it matters most.
3. **Check privacy settings together**
   Make it normal, not a one-off.
4. **Talk about messaging specifically**
   This is where most issues start.
5. **Keep conversations ongoing**
   Not just one big talk.

THE RISKS WORTH KNOWING

- Private messaging with unknown people
- Group chat pressure and bullying
- Exposure to inappropriate content
- Overuse and sleep disruption
- False sense of safety ("friends only")

THE 10-MINUTE CONVERSATION

Opening line:
"Which apps do you use the most at the moment?"

Questions that work:
- Which one do you spend the most time on?
- Do you message people on all of these?
- Do you know everyone you talk to?
- Has anything ever felt uncomfortable?

Key principle:
Stay curious · Stay calm · Keep the door open

IF THINGS GO WRONG

STAY CALM & GATHER EVIDENCE
- Screenshot messages or content
- Don't delete immediately

REPORT & SEEK HELP
- Use in-app reporting tools
- Speak to school if peers are involved
- Contact Childline for support

CHILDLINE SUPPORT
0800 1111
childline.org.uk

CLOSING MESSAGE
It's not about keeping up with every app.
It's about understanding how your child uses them – and keeping communication open.

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